will be no effective monitoring of what animals are being killed and whether hunters are adhering to norms. And as far as crop protection goes, there is always the option of translocating [animals] rather than culling."

Groups like the True Conservation Alliance (TCA)—founded by legal researcher Meghna Uniyal, agriculturist and photographer-film maker Ryan Lobo and agriculturist Marcus Campos—are looking to reframe the perception of hunting as a crop-protection measure and a tool to generate profit. It is pushing for regulated hunting to be permitted outside protected areas (sanctuaries and national parks), saying this will improve wildlife management. "This will engage the local population to protect wildlife, since that will give them revenue," says Lobo. The TCA has also argued for the WPA to be renamed the Wild Resources Management Act, rather than the Wild Life (Protection) Act, which offers as clear a look at the heart of this debate as one might hope for: whether wild animals are life to be protected or resources to be managed.

The group is also pushing for more community ownership of wildlife to bring investment into the sector. It highlights Namibia's example, saying about half that country uses wildlife as a resource to generate revenue. It adds that many countries allow hunting, and says Pakistan's *markhor* (mountain goat) conservation programme owes its success largely to sport hunting. Under this model, a limited number of hunting permits are issued each year, bringing in around $10,000 (Rs 7.5 lakh) each, with 80 per cent of the revenue earmarked for local communities.

Many farmer associations also support the push to legalise hunting, though for different reasons. "Existing laws do not protect farmers from crop-raiding animals," says Chengal Reddy, head of the Hyderabad-based Consortium of Indian Farmers Associations. "What is worrying is that the problem has increased over the years. We receive regular complaints about monkeys and wild boars in south India and *nilgai* (blue bulls) in north India raiding crops. And there is no scientific method to compensate farmers for their losses. In such a situation, it could be a good idea to allow some culling." Also noting the potential commercial benefit, he adds that hunting could "lead to enhancement of incomes through tourism".

The TCA has also attacked the WPA on other grounds—for example, claiming it infringes on religious traditions that involve hunting and alleging the WPA itself was an attempt by the Indira Gandhi government to supersede the traditional hunting rights of locals and local rulers. Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's government did battle with former princes over traditional privileges like the privy purse. However, experts like Dr Ranjitsinh—who is of princely descent himself—says that while Prime Minister Gandhi and the former royals were often at loggerheads, he does not believe there was any intent to attack them through the WPA. "Mrs Gandhi informed me that a group of tribal MPs had opposed the WPA on the grounds that their traditional rights would be curtailed," he recollects. "The ministry of tribal welfare had also opposed the Act in the cabinet. Mrs Gandhi wanted the tribal MPs to be convinced that the Act was for the good of wildlife. [My position was] that there were other communities in the country—such as former royals—who traditionally hunted as well, and that if an exception was made for tribal traditions, it would have to be made for other groups too. I also asked the ministry of tribal welfare if there were any rights like hunting rituals established for tribals in the law. It did not produce any such law," he says.

Though India has broadly banned hunting since 1972, in recent years, some states in India have temporarily declared some species as 'vermin' to permit their culling in cases of extreme conflict. Among others, Bihar has al-

NO SANCTUARY The killing of 'Cecil the lion' by a trophy hunter with a permit just outside a national park in Zimbabwe in July 2015 sparked global outrage



ZIMBABWE NATIONAL PARKS/AFP



REGULATED HUNTING

"The IPC allows the use of force against others to prevent bodily harm or loss of property. There is no reason why farmers should not be allowed to similarly protect their crops"

MADHAV GADGIL
Founder, Centre for Ecological Sciences